Axiology Checklist

Fillable PDF. Click a blue box to type; tick the small squares. Save with **File › Save** and attach the saved PDF to your assignment. Works best in the free Adobe Acrobat Reader; macOS Preview and web browsers also work. If an answer does not fit its box, continue it on an extra page. Source: `Step_01_Epistemological_Alignment_and_Method_Selection/axiology_checklist.md` (rebuild with `tools/make_fillable_pdfs.py`).

Before deciding on your methods, evaluate the underlying values and motivations driving this research. Documenting these helps clarify the most appropriate research paradigm and ethical approach.

1. Core Values and Drivers

☐ What is the ultimate goal of this research? (e.g., advancing theoretical ecology, solving a specific conservation conflict, empowering a local community)

☐ Who are the primary stakeholders or beneficiaries?

☐ How do the researchers' own backgrounds, biases, and values intersect with this context?

2. Intended Use and Outcomes

☐ **Empirical / Neutral:** Are you aiming to produce generalizable, "objective" estimates (e.g., what percentage of landowners support a policy)? (*Leans toward Positivist/Surveys*)

☐ **Interpretive / Contextual:** Are you aiming to deeply understand how a specific group makes meaning of an ecological phenomenon? (*Leans toward Constructivist/Qualitative*)

☐ **Pragmatic / Management-Driven:** Is the primary aim to find a functional solution to a management problem? (*Leans toward Pragmatism/Mixed Methods*)

☐ **Advocacy / Critical:** Is the research explicitly intended to challenge power dynamics or advocate for an marginalized group? (*Leans toward Critical/Participatory Methods*)

3. Ethical and Engagement Considerations

- [ ] What is the ethical impact of the chosen methodology on the community?

- [ ] Will standardized instruments be too rigid, culturally inappropriate, or extractive?

- [ ] Do stakeholders need to be involved in co-designing the research questions or instruments?

Keep this checklist with your study design documentation to justify your paradigm choice.